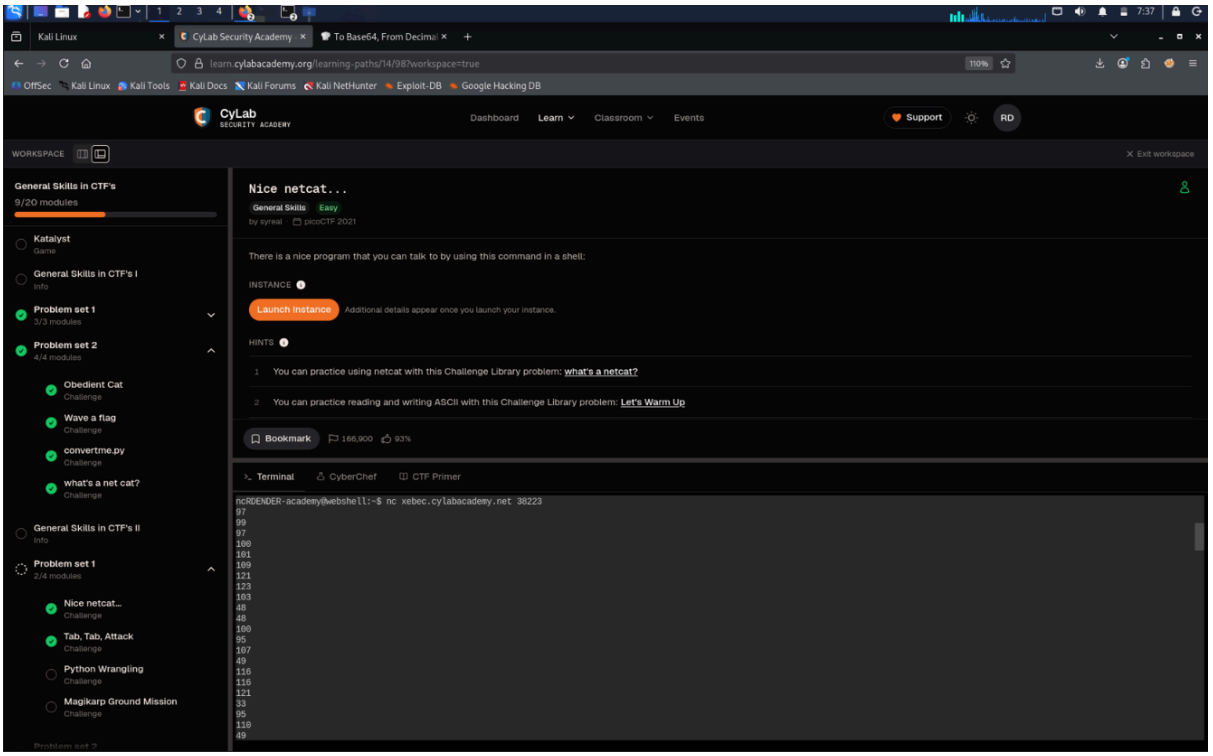
NICE NETCAT||CYLAB ACADEMY(formerly PicoCTF)||EASY

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CATEGORY:General Skills(II)
Key skills:Netcat,CyberChef,Data format conversions

Summary:
Nice Netcat is a easy difficulty challenge in Cylab Academy which tests the user's abilities in Netcat and Data format conversions(specifically ASCII) The challenge requires the user to Netcat a random server and port and convert the given output to a proper flag.

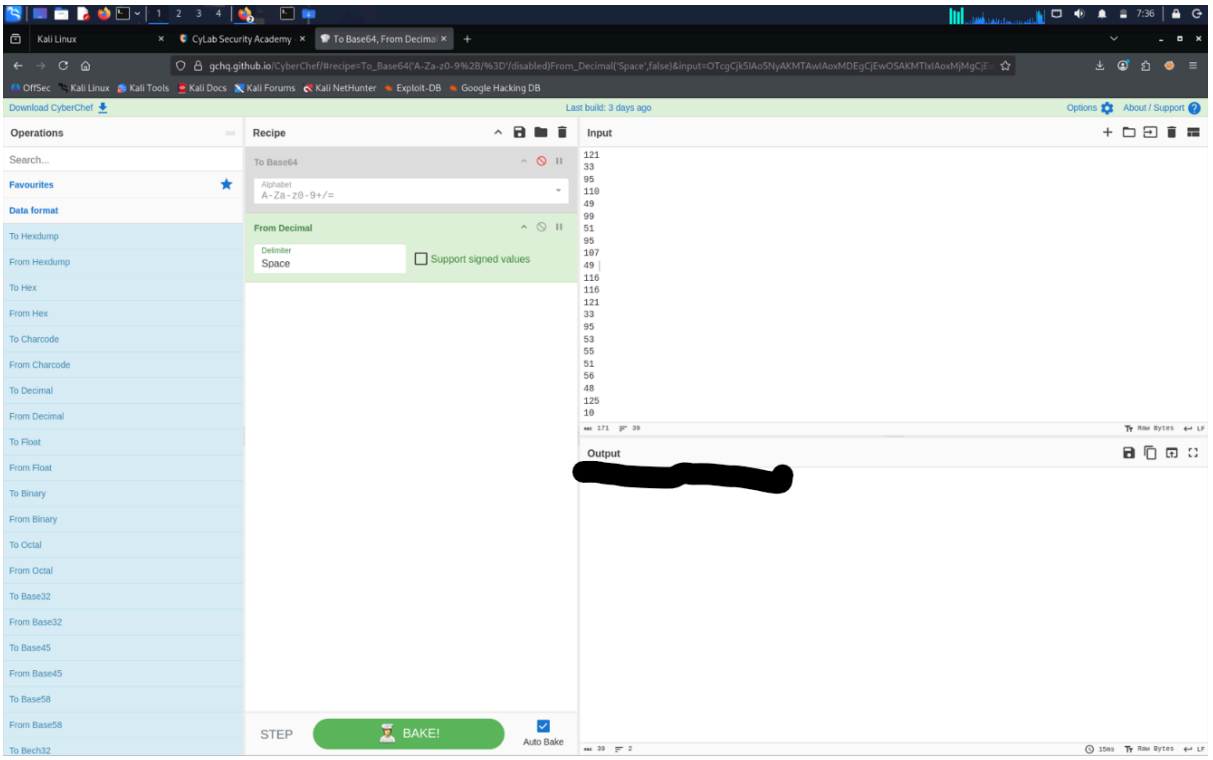
Enumeration:

1. I used the command nc to access the server already given in the challenge.



(disclaimer,here the instance is not running as I had already closed it and was in the process of cracking another challenge during the time of this screenshot due to which the full question did not appear here.)

2.From the output,we can see multiple numbers and we are expected to convert this ASCII decimal format to a proper flag output.The best tool for this is the open source tool Cyberchef
3. In cyberchef,initially i made a mistake of conversion to Base64 which gave a significantly long and visibly wrong output hence I ignored it.After testing different recipes with the tool for a while, I realised the whole output is decimal and we need to convert it to ASCII so <from decimal> is the correct command.



(as we can see evidence,of my previous mistake to Base64(which isnt ASCII format,our day to day format,ofcourse i decommissioned it and implemented From decimal)

4.Here (covered in black,to avoid spoilers) is the correct flag and i had passed the challenge.

LESSONS LEARNED:

Here I finally understood the applications of data format conversions,the major mistake I made was not technical implementation but incorrect analysis of the output.Now I understand if an output is purely numbers it could be decimal,similarly if its only 1's and 0's,it is binary and so on.The difficulty with cyberchef isnt its implementation(its GUI is very convenient) but potential misidentification of the format.To differentiate ASCII from other encodings, I can use a tool like CyberChef's 'Magic' feature or observe that the numbers fall within the printable ASCII range (e.g., 112 105 99 111 represents 'pico').